

time and attention—to your kids *now*. Rather than wearing yourself out on the job, you can play with your children. Rather than racing around the country to attend meetings, you can spend whole summers traveling with your family. Rather than staying late at the office, you can watch your kids take swimming lessons, act in a play, or do gymnastics. When you retire you free up eight, ten, or twelve hours a day, five days a week. You can spend all the time you want with your kids. And remember that kids need time *without* you. Kids want to play alone, be with their friends, or go places with their brothers or sisters. You'll still have plenty of time left over for your to-do list.

You'll recall that the three-part formula for very early retirement is:

Do your arithmetic

Do some soul-searching

Do what you want

Let's take a look at how to apply that formula when you retire with kids.

DO YOUR ARITHMETIC

The first part of the three-part formula is financial. We've seen that two people need \$400,000 or \$500,000 to retire. How much more do you need if you have kids?

As a minimum, I believe you need \$11 a day, or \$4,000 a year, for each child.

Business Week surveys how much money it takes to support a family of four. So do *Time*, *Newsweek*, and other publications. Their surveys come up with remarkably similar numbers. Raising a child in America today, assuming he or she goes to public schools, costs about \$5,000 a year.

Now, I know people who spend \$5,000 on their 6-year-old's birthday party. And who knows how many ponies the \$5,000